

Bulgaria



A mountainous Slav country on the Black Sea that was once at the heart of the Byzantine Empire.

681 Byzantium cedes the territories north of the Balkan ridge to Khan Asparuh and the first Bulgarian state, with its capital at Pliska, emerges, peopled by Bulgars, tribes of Slavic and Turkic origin who have settled in the region over the preceding 200 years.

865 During the reign of Boris I, Bulgaria accepts Christianity; the church follows the Slavonic liturgy, introduced by disciples of Cyril and Methodius. An expansion of the kingdom under Boris's son Simeon from 893 is accompanied by a flourishing in the arts.

1242 A golden age, during which the Bulgarian state again expands to the dimensions of Simeon's empire (with its capital at Tarnovo), is ended by the Mongol invasion, causing the Bulgarian state to splinter.

1393–96 Bulgaria is conquered by the Turks. The Bulgarian Patriarchate is suppressed, and the church turns toward the Greek Orthodox Church. Turkish domination lasts almost 500 years, and Turks settle in several regions of Bulgaria.

1876 An uprising against the Turks, originating in Bosnia in 1875, is brutally suppressed, attracting sympathy for the Bulgarian cause from the Great Powers.

1878 After the defeat of the Ottoman Empire in the Russo-Turkish War of 1877–78, the Treaty of San Stefano is signed. It would have created a new, greater Bulgarian state stretching from the Danube to the Aegean. Britain and Austria-Hungary force Russia to reconsider, and the new Bulgaria is divided into three parts by the Treaty of Berlin concluded a few months later: a Bulgarian principality, north of the

Balkan mountains; Eastern Rumelia south of the Balkan mountains and under Turkish rule; and Macedonia and Eastern Thrace.

1885 Eastern Rumelia is added to the Bulgarian principality by force. A dispute between Bulgaria and Russia results in the abdication of the Bulgarian ruler Alexander of Battenberg (elected in 1879), and the election in 1887 by the National Assembly of the pro-Austrian Ferdinand of Saxe-Coburg to the throne.

1908 After Austria-Hungary annexes Bosnia-Herzegovina, Bulgaria declares itself an independent kingdom, and Ferdinand proclaims himself czar.

1912 Bulgaria, Serbia, Greece, and Montenegro defeat Turkey in the First Balkan War, and divide Turkish Macedonia between them. Bulgaria feels aggrieved by the settlement and in 1913 attacks its former allies, who are now joined by Romania and Turkey, but is quickly defeated, losing Dobruja to Romania in the north, Thrace in the southeast to Turkey, and most of its gains in Macedonia to Greece and Serbia.

1915–18 Bulgaria enters World War I on the side of the Central Powers to avenge its defeat in the 1913 Balkan War, and declares war on Serbia.

1919 By the Treaty of Neuilly, the defeated Bulgaria loses all of Thrace, and thus its coastline on the Aegean, to Greece, and hands over territory in Macedonia to Yugoslavia.

1920 The left-wing Agrarian Party wins power. The Communist Party, also strong in the country's first parliament, refuses to participate in government.

1923 Prime Minister Aleksandur Stamboliski is killed in a coup. Insurrections by the agrarians and communists fail. Terrorist organizations become active. A succession of coalition governments lasts until a military government seizes power in a coup.

1934 King Boris III establishes his personal dictatorship.

1941 Boris signs Tripartite Pact with Nazi Germany and its allies and permits the German army to occupy its territory. Bulgaria joins the Axis powers and takes part in the occupation of Yugoslavia, for which it is granted much of Macedonia.

1943 After Boris III dies suddenly, the six-year-old Simeon II succeeds him.

1944 Allies firebomb Sofia as the Soviet army invades. An antifascist Fatherland Front coalition, including the Agrarian and Bulgarian Communist (BCP) parties, takes power in a bloodless coup. Kimon Georgiev is prime minister.

1946 Referendum abolishes the monarchy and a republic is proclaimed. A general election results in a BCP majority.

DECISIVE MOMENT

CONGRESS OF BERLIN, 1878

Bulgarians celebrate their national day on March 3. On this day in 1878 the Treaty of Stefano was signed, ending the Russo-Turkish War and granting independence to Ottoman-controlled Bulgaria. The idea for the new state was short-lived, however. On June 13 the major European powers met in Berlin to rewrite the settlement (below). The UK wanted to limit Russian influence

in the Mediterranean by propping up the failing Ottomans. Meanwhile, Austria-Hungary wished to extend its influence in the Balkans. As a result, Bulgaria was vastly reduced, losing Macedonia and Eastern Rumelia in the resulting Treaty of Berlin. The aspirations of the peoples of the Balkans themselves were all but ignored in the new treaty, sowing the seeds for future crises in the region.



1946 The country is renamed the People's Republic of Bulgaria.

1947 Prime Minister Georgi Dimitrov discredits Agrarian Party leader Nikola Petkov, who is arrested and sentenced to death. A Soviet-style constitution is adopted and a one-party state established. Nationalization of the economy begins.

1949 Dimitrov dies and is succeeded as prime minister by Vasil Kolarov. After he dies in 1950, he is replaced by "Little Stalin," Vulko Chervenkov, who begins a BCP purge and mass collectivization.

1953 Joseph Stalin dies and Chervenkov's power begins to wane.

1954 Chervenkov yields position of First Secretary to Todor Zhivkov, who sets out to make Bulgaria an inseparable part of the Soviet system.

1955–60 Zhivkov exonerates victims of Chervenkov's purges.

1965 Plot to overthrow Zhivkov is discovered by Soviet agents.

1968 Bulgarian troops aid Soviet army in invasion of Czechoslovakia.

1971 New constitution: Zhivkov becomes Chairman of the State Council and resigns as premier.

1978 Purge of BCP: about 30,000 members expelled.

1984 Turkish minority is forced to take Slavic names.

1989 About 300,000 Bulgarian Turks are forced out by Bulgarian discrimination. Zhivkov is ousted as BCP leader; replaced by Petar Mladenov. Mass protest in Sofia for democratic reform. The Union of Democratic Forces (UDF) is formed.

1990 Economic and political collapse: BCP loses constitutional role as leading political party and changes name to Bulgarian Socialist Party (BSP). A general election produces no overall result but Zhelyu Zhelev, UDF leader, becomes president, with the BSP in government. The country is renamed Republic of Bulgaria and communist symbols are removed from the national flag.

1991 New constitution adopted: UDF wins elections.

1992 Continued unrest as the UDF resigns after losing a vote of confidence and the BSP and Movement for Rights and Freedoms (MRF) form a coalition government. Zhivkov is convicted of corruption and human rights abuses.

1993 Privatization program begins.

1994 General elections return BSP to power.

1996 Financial crisis. Presidential elections won by opposition UDF candidate, Peter Stoyanov.

1997 General election won by UDF with Ivan Kostov as prime minister.

2001 Despite economic upturn, voters turn to new party headed by the ex-king, who becomes prime minister under the name of Simeon Saksoburggotski.

2004 Joins NATO.

2007 Joins EU.

2008 EU suspends aid to Bulgaria over levels of corruption there and failure to tackle organized crime.

«110–13 From Republic to Empire

«150–51 Decline and Fall?

«198–99 The Byzantine Empire



Converting the pagans

Saints Cyril and Methodius, portrayed here in an Orthodox church icon, set out in 863 to convert pagan Slavs to Orthodox Christianity, which became the dominant religion of Bulgaria.